

Executive-brief writing: clear answers from researched evidence

The **executive-brief-writing** skill turns researched evidence on any topic into a concise explanation, decision brief or recommendation for an executive reader. It can serve a vendor choice, an operating question, a policy issue or a research update. The answer comes first, with the uncertainty that could change the reader's decision. [1]

Why the approach is useful

Digital.gov recommends writing for the audience's knowledge and organizing the answer up front. Its paraphrase test asks readers to explain meaning and intended action in their own words. Applied here, the test is whether an executive can recover the answer and its conditions without an explanation from the author. This is a design rationale, not proof that this skill improves human understanding. [2]; [3]

Clear prose still needs evidence. Gao and colleagues' ALCE research treats fluency, factual correctness and citation quality as separate questions. Its 2023 results motivate inspecting source support rather than trusting a polished, referenced answer; they do not estimate current-model reliability. [4]

Where reviewers should focus

- **An attractive answer outruns its sources:** open the original evidence and check that it supports the actual recommendation, including material contrary findings.
- **A shorter brief loses a condition:** compare the opening answer with the evidence. In a hypothetical supplier brief, a saving that applies only to low-volume orders must keep that condition beside the recommendation.
- **A reader merely agrees:** ask a fresh reader what they understood, what they would do and what could change the answer. Inspect the final PDF after corrections. [1]; [3]; [4]

What is established, and how to start

A local comparison included four initial author cases across executive and technical writing. Three of the four initial drafts needed corrections to evidence attribution or scope. Final agent reviewers and fresh agent readers passed the revised documents after a source correction. This demonstrates feasibility in those cases, not average quality, savings or human-reader benefit. The comparison delivered Markdown and did not test PDF appearance. This PDF is a separate demonstration. [5]

Start with one brief, the reader's question and concise evidence notes. Add managed records when changing sources or repeated publication make version tracking useful; use a dependency graph only when coordination warrants it. The scope is any researched topic: R&D was the demonstration setting. [1]

References

- [1] Finalized executive-brief-writing skill. Local project record, archived as sources/S01-SKILL.md.
- [2] U.S. General Services Administration. Principles of plain language. <https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language/principles/> Accessed 2026-10-09.
- [3] U.S. General Services Administration. Paraphrase testing. <https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language/test/paraphrase-testing> Accessed 2026-10-09.
- [4] Gao, T., Yen, H., Yu, J. and Chen, D. (2023). Enabling Large Language Models to Generate Text with Citations. EMNLP. <https://aclanthology.org/2023.emnlp-main.398/> Accessed 2026-10-09.
- [5] Writing workflow evaluation and limitations. Local project record, archived as sources/S03-RESULTS.md.